THE LOST JAWANS

The Agnipath scheme has left hundreds of thousands of possible army recruits, who were on the verge of enrolment, out in the cold

By **PRADIP R. SAGAR**



7,000
NO. OF AIRMEN CANDIDATES WHO WERE WAITING FOR FINAL LIST (AFTER GOING THROUGH THE SELECTION PROCESS). NOW INVALID

The son of a farmer in Bhiwani district, Haryana, 21-year-old Sonu was always in awe of the military. In fact, seeing himself in uniform was his ultimate dream. So, after finishing his 12th in a non-science stream at his village school in 2018, he started preparing for the Indian Air Force airmen (technical) tests.

Sonu flunked his first two attempts, but didn't lose heart. His father mortgaged their ancestral land and took a bank loan of Rs 8 lakh to send him to a coaching centre in Rohtak, 100 km away. On his third attempt, he cleared the written test (held after the first Covid wave, in November 2020) and then went for the physical and situation reaction tests. His dream 'almost' came true when his name figured in the provisional selection list, which came out on May 31, 2021, but the authorities kept delaying the final list blaming the pandemic.

A little over a year later, his hopes were dashed when on June 14, the ministry of defence introduced the Agnipath scheme for all recruitments into the three services. Sonu is amongst the 7,000 candidates who have gone through the IAF's recruitment process only to see their hopes dashed by the new norms.

Last month, the government announced the Agnipath scheme, under which youths between the ages of 17-and-a-half and 21 would be inducted into the armed forces for a four-year tenure, while 25 per cent of them will be subsequently inducted for regular 'colour service' (the full extended service period of 17 years). The scheme is aimed at making a 'lean and mean' military by reducing the medi-